CHAPTER 15 · REFERENCE DEPTH

Aerodrome Control: Aircraft

This is the chapter the practical examiner listens for. Standard phraseology is a script — the same words, in the same order, for every phase of flight — so that a controller in Delhi and a pilot from anywhere understand each other instantly. Here we walk a flight from clearance and start, through taxi, take-off, the circuit, final approach and landing, the go-around, and vacating.

SYLLABUS MAP

Part III (iii) Aerodrome control – aircraft: departure info, start, push-back, taxi, take-off, circuit, final & landing, go-around, after landing

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◎ Learning objectives — by the end of this chapter you will be able to...

- Describe the aerodrome controller's responsibilities and the manoeuvring area.
- Use the correct phraseology for clearance delivery, start-up and push-back.
- Use taxi phraseology, including holding points, "give way" and conditional clearances.

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- Use line-up and take-off phraseology and the circuit reporting points.
- Use final-approach, landing and go-around phraseology.
- Use after-landing and vacating phraseology.

15.1 The aerodrome controller

15.2 Clearance & departure information

15.3 Start-up & push-back

15.4 Taxi

15.5 Line-up & take-off

15.6 The traffic circuit

15.7 Final approach & landing

15.8 Go-around

15.9 After landing & vacating

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From engine start to the final runway vacation, strict adherence to standard phraseology is the foundation of aerodrome safety.

15.1 The aerodrome controller

IN PLAIN TERMS

Aerodrome control (**Tower**) is responsible for traffic on the **runways and in the aerodrome traffic circuit**, and for vehicles and aircraft on the **manoeuvring area**. The **manoeuvring area** is the runways and taxiways used for take-off, landing and taxiing — but **not** the aprons. The **movement area** is the manoeuvring area **plus** the aprons.

TWO DEFINITIONS TO KEEP STRAIGHT

Manoeuvring area = runways + taxiways (for take-off, landing, taxiing); excludes aprons. **Movement area** = manoeuvring area + aprons.
Ground/Tower control the manoeuvring area; the apron may be managed separately ("Apron").

15.2 Clearance & departure information

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WHY A CLEARANCE IS READ BACK IN FULL

An IFR departure clearance is a contract: it states **where** you are cleared, by what **route**, to what **level**, and the **squawk**. Because an error here propagates into controlled airspace, the whole clearance is a mandatory read-back.

TRANSCRIPT — IFR CLEARANCE (DELIVERY)

A/C Delhi Delivery, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, stand two one, request IFR clearance to Mumbai, information Charlie.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, cleared to Mumbai via PAPA two departure, climb flight level one zero zero, squawk four three two one.

A/C Cleared to Mumbai via PAPA two departure, climb flight level one zero zero, squawk four three two one, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, read-back correct.

DEPARTURE INFORMATION

Before taxi the pilot needs the **runway in use, surface wind, QNH** and any essential information — usually obtained from **ATIS** (Chapter 6) and confirmed on first contact ("…information Charlie"). The controller passes anything ATIS does not cover.

15.3 Start-up & push-back

TRANSCRIPT — START & PUSH

A/C Delhi Ground, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, stand two one, request start-up.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, start-up approved.

A/C Request push-back.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, push-back approved, facing south.

A/C Push-back approved, facing south, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie.

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EXAM TRAP

"Start-up approved" permits engine start, not movement. **Push-back is a separate clearance**, and the controller may give the direction to face. Never push or taxi on a start-up clearance alone.

15.4 Taxi

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TRANSCRIPT — TAXI

A/C Delhi Ground, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, request taxi.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, taxi to holding point Alfa One runway two seven via taxiway Bravo, QNH one zero one three.

A/C Taxi to holding point Alfa One runway two seven via Bravo, QNH one zero one three, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie.

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KEY TAXI PHRASES

"Hold position" — stop where you are. **"Give way to [traffic]"** — let the named traffic pass. **"Follow [traffic]"**. **"Hold short of runway 27"** / **"holding point Alfa One"** — stop at the marked point and do not enter the runway. A clearance to taxi **does not** include clearance to enter or cross a runway.

EXAM TRAP — RUNWAY ENTRY

Taxiing to a holding point is **not** permission to enter the runway. Entering, crossing or backtracking a runway each needs its own explicit clearance — and each is a mandatory read-back.

15.5 Line-up & take-off

TRANSCRIPT — LINE-UP & DEPARTURE

A/C Delhi Tower, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, holding point Alfa One, ready for departure.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, line up runway two seven and wait.

A/C Line up runway two seven and wait, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie.

ATC Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, wind two seven zero degrees eight knots, runway two seven, cleared for take-off.

A/C Runway two seven, cleared for take-off, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie.

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TAKE-OFF PHRASEOLOGY — EXACT WORDS

The word **"take-off"** is used **only** when issuing or cancelling a take-off clearance — at all other times say "departure". **"Cleared for take-off"** / read back **"cleared for take-off"**. To cancel: **"hold position, cancel take-off, I say again cancel take-off"**. An **"immediate take-off"** may be issued if traffic requires.

WORKED EXAMPLE — CONDITIONAL LINE-UP

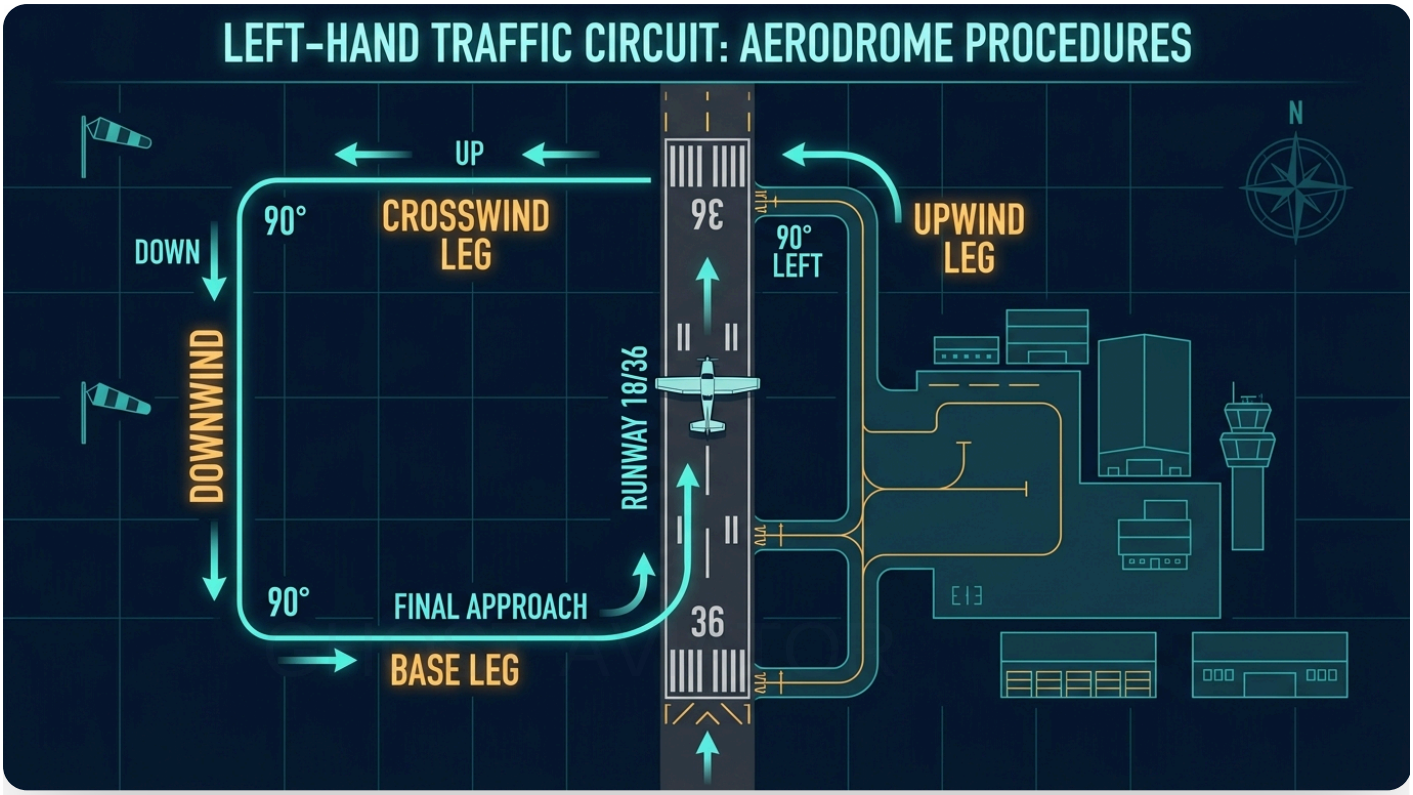
ATC: "Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie, **behind the landing Airbus**, line up runway two seven **behind**."
Correct read-back: "Behind the landing Airbus, line up runway two seven behind, Ghostair Alfa Bravo Charlie." The word "behind" is said **twice** — at the start and end — so the condition cannot be missed. Do not move until the Airbus has passed.

15.6 The aerodrome traffic circuit

IN PLAIN TERMS

The circuit is the standard rectangular pattern flown around a runway. Its legs — **upwind/crosswind, downwind, base, final** — are the reporting points the tower uses to sequence visual traffic.

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The visual traffic circuit provides a predictable, standardized pattern for VFR aircraft to maneuver and sequence for landing.

Circuit Legs	
Leg	**Where**
Upwind / climb-out	Straight ahead after take-off
Crosswind	Turn (usually 90°) across the upwind end
Downwind	Parallel to the runway, opposite direction to landing
Base	Turn toward final, descending

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Leg	Where
Final	Lined up with the runway for landing

TRANSCRIPT — JOINING & CIRCUIT REPORTS

A/C Delhi Tower, VT-ABC, five miles north, for landing, information Charlie.

ATC VT-ABC, join left-hand downwind runway two seven, QNH one zero one three, report downwind.

A/C Join left-hand downwind runway two seven, QNH one zero one three, wilco, VT-ABC.

A/C VT-ABC, downwind.

ATC VT-ABC, number two, follow the Cessna on base, report final.

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15.7 Final approach & landing

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TRANSCRIPT — FINAL & LANDING

A/C VT-ABC, final.

ATC VT-ABC, wind two seven zero degrees one zero knots, runway two seven, cleared to land.

A/C Runway two seven, cleared to land, VT-ABC.

LANDING VARIATIONS

"Continue approach" — keep approaching; landing clearance not yet given.
"Land after the departing/landing [traffic]" — a conditional landing clearance behind preceding traffic. **"Cleared to land"** is the full clearance and a mandatory read-back.

15.8 Go-around

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↑ THE GO-AROUND / MISSED APPROACH

If the approach must be discontinued, the instruction is **"go around"** (said clearly, often twice). The pilot applies power, climbs, and flies the missed-approach procedure or the tower's instructions. A pilot may also initiate a go-around without being told — reporting **"going around"**.

TRANSCRIPT — GO-AROUND

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ATC VT-ABC, go around, I say again, go around, vehicle on the runway.

A/C Going around, VT-ABC.

ATC VT-ABC, climb straight ahead to two thousand feet, report downwind.

15.9 After landing & vacating

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TRANSCRIPT — VACATING

ATC VT-ABC, vacate next left, contact Ground one two one decimal nine.

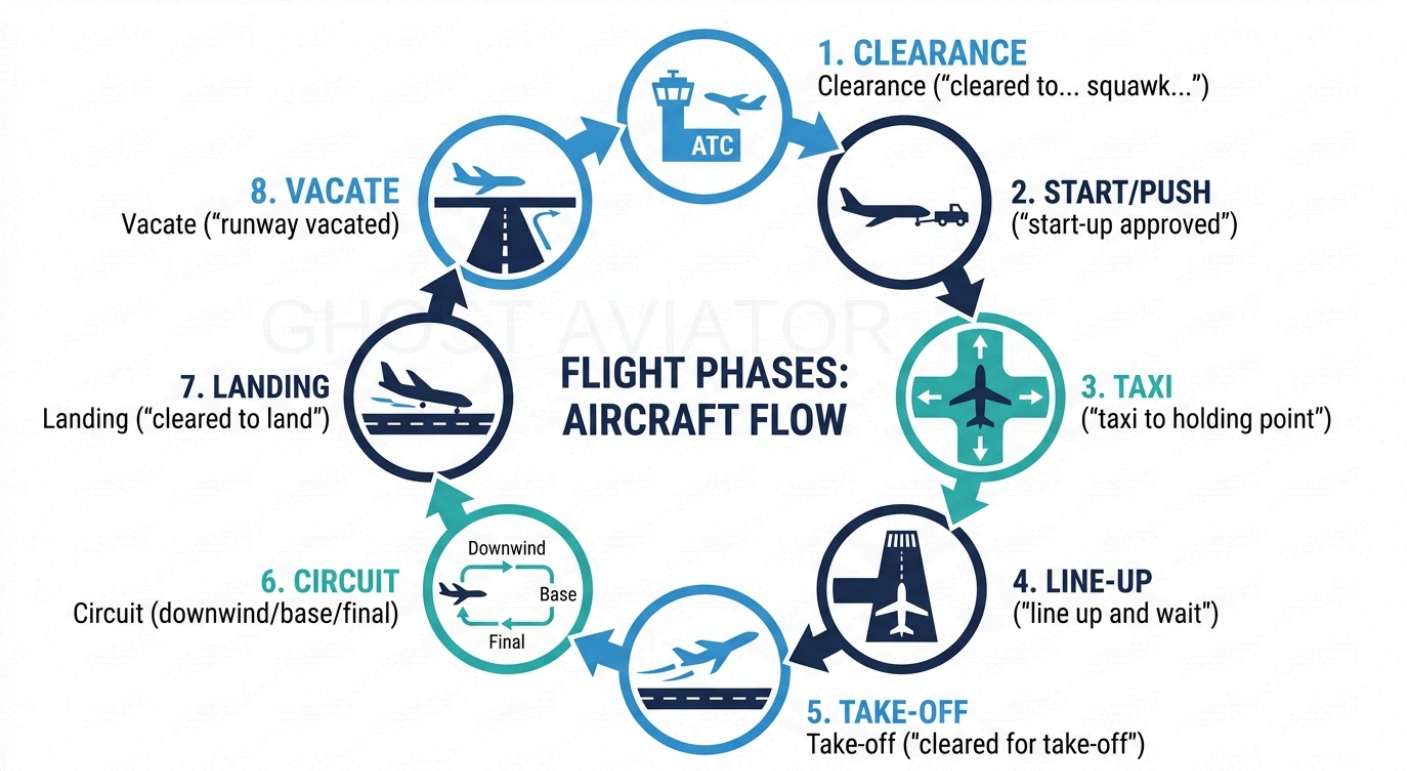
A/C Vacate next left, Ground one two one decimal nine, VT-ABC.

A/C Delhi Ground, VT-ABC, runway vacated, request taxi to apron.

ATC VT-ABC, taxi to stand two one via taxiway Bravo.

EXAM TRAP — "RUNWAY VACATED"

You are not clear of the runway until the whole aircraft is past the holding point. Report **"runway vacated"** only when fully clear — this releases the runway for the next aircraft, so accuracy matters.



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Figure 15.1 — A flight in phraseology: the critical communication nodes from clearance to vacating the runway.

☆ Numbers to memorise

Essential Facts for Chapter 15	
Fact	**Value**
Manoeuvring vs movement area	Manoeuvring = runways+taxiways; Movement = + aprons
"Take-off"	Used only to issue/cancel a take-off clearance; else "departure"
Start vs push	"Start-up approved" ≠ movement; push-back is a separate clearance
Runway entry	Taxi to a holding point ≠ clearance to enter/cross/backtrack
Conditional clearance	Condition stated first & last ("behind … behind")
Circuit legs	Upwind · crosswind · downwind · base · final
Landing phrases	Continue approach / cleared to land / land after

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Fact	Value
Go-around	"Go around" (often twice); pilot may initiate "going around"

Question bank

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Part A — MCQs (click an option to check)

1. The manoeuvring area consists of:

Aprons only

Runways and taxiways (excluding aprons)

Runways, taxiways and aprons

The terminal building

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Answer: Runways and taxiways (excluding aprons).

Manoeuvring area = runways + taxiways; adding aprons makes it the movement area.

2. An IFR departure clearance must be:

Acknowledged with "roger"

Read back in full

Read back only if requested

Not read back

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Answer: Read back in full.

Route clearances are mandatory read-back items.

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3. "Start-up approved" permits:

Push-back and taxi

Engine start only

Take-off

Crossing the runway

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Answer: Engine start only.

It allows engine start; push-back and taxi are separate clearances.

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4. The word "take-off" is used:

Throughout the taxi

Only when issuing or cancelling a take-off clearance

For any departure intention

Only by the pilot

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Answer: Only when issuing or cancelling a take-off clearance.

Otherwise "departure" is used, to reserve "take-off" for the clearance itself.

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5. Taxiing to a holding point gives you:

Clearance to line up

Clearance to cross the runway

No clearance to enter the runway — stop at the holding point

Clearance for take-off

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Answer: No clearance to enter the runway.

A taxi clearance to a holding point does not authorise entering the runway.

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6. "Give way to the Cessna" means:

Follow the Cessna

Let the Cessna pass before you continue

Overtake the Cessna

Stop permanently

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Answer: Let the Cessna pass before you continue.

Give way = yield to the named traffic, then continue.

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7. "Line up runway 27 and wait" means:

Take off immediately

Enter the runway, line up, and hold for take-off clearance

Hold short of the runway

Vacate the runway

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Answer: Enter the runway, line up, and hold for take-off clearance.

You line up on the runway but do not take off until cleared.

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8. A conditional clearance such as "behind the landing Airbus, line up behind" requires:

Immediate line-up

Waiting until the named Airbus has passed, reading the condition back

A go-around

Contacting Ground

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Answer: Waiting until the named Airbus has passed, reading the condition back.

You act only after the stated condition is satisfied, and read it back including "behind".

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9. The downwind leg of the circuit is:

Straight ahead after take-off

Parallel to the runway, opposite to the landing direction

Lined up for landing

The turn onto final

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Answer: Parallel to the runway, opposite to the landing direction.

Downwind runs parallel to the runway in the opposite direction; base then turns toward final.

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10. "Continue approach" means:

You are cleared to land

Keep approaching; landing clearance not yet given

Go around

Vacate the runway

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Answer: Keep approaching; landing clearance not yet given.

It is not a landing clearance; expect the landing clearance shortly.

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11. "Cleared to land" is:

Not read back

A mandatory read-back item

Read back only at night

Optional

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Answer: A mandatory read-back item.

Landing clearances are mandatory read-back items.

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12. The instruction to discontinue an approach is:

"Orbit"

"Go around"

"Hold position"

"Continue"

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Answer: "Go around".

"Go around" (often said twice) commands the missed approach.

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13. A pilot who initiates a missed approach reports:

"Roger"

"Going around"

"Cancel landing"

"Vacating"

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Answer: "Going around".

The pilot announces "going around" when initiating it.

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14. You should report "runway vacated" when:

The nose passes the holding point

The whole aircraft is clear past the holding point

You begin to slow

You are on final

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Answer: The whole aircraft is clear past the holding point.

Only when fully clear of the runway, releasing it for the next aircraft.

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15. To cancel a take-off clearance, ATC says:

"Continue"

"Hold position, cancel take-off, I say again cancel take-off"

"Line up and wait"

"Go around"

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Answer: "Hold position, cancel take-off, I say again cancel take-off".

The cancellation uses "cancel take-off", repeated for emphasis.

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16. Surface wind passed with a take-off/landing clearance is in:

Degrees true

Degrees magnetic

Knots only

Metres per second

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Answer: Degrees magnetic.

ATC passes surface wind in degrees magnetic (the runway is also magnetic).

Part B — Oral / viva (tap to reveal model answers)

▼ ? **Define the manoeuvring area and the movement area.**

Model Answer:

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The manoeuvring area is the part of an aerodrome used for take-off, landing and taxiing — the runways and taxiways, excluding aprons. The movement area is the manoeuvring area plus the aprons.

▼ ? **What does an IFR departure clearance contain, and how is it acknowledged?**

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Model Answer:

The clearance limit (destination), the route/departure, the cleared level, and the squawk. It is read back in full because it is a route clearance.

▼ ? When is the word "take-off" used?

Model Answer:

Only when issuing or cancelling a take-off clearance; at all other times the word "departure" is used.

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▼ ? What must you do on a conditional clearance, e.g. "behind the landing aircraft, line up behind"?

Model Answer:

Identify the stated traffic, read the clearance back including the condition (the word "behind" said first and last), and only act once that traffic has passed.

▼ ? Name the legs of the aerodrome traffic circuit.

Model Answer:

Upwind/climb-out, crosswind, downwind, base and final.

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▼ ? What is the difference between "continue approach" and "cleared to land"?

Model Answer:

"Continue approach" means keep approaching but you are not yet cleared to land; "cleared to land" is the full landing clearance and a mandatory read-back.

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⚡ 60-SECOND REVISION CARD

Manoeuvring = runways+taxiways; **movement** = + aprons. Clearance read back in full.

Start ≠ push ≠ taxi (separate clearances). Taxi to holding point ≠ enter runway.

"Take-off" only for the clearance; **line up and wait** → **cleared for take-off**. Conditional = "behind … behind".

Circuit: upwind·crosswind·**downwind·base·final**. **Continue approach** / **cleared to land** / **land after**.

Go around (twice); report **going around**; report **runway vacated** only when fully clear.

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